Adjutant in the unit when he was the Commanding Officer. We shared an excellent rapport and I looked forward to chatting with him.

On reaching the office and after taking a cool drink of water, I asked the exchange to put the call through. And then came the bombshell. 'Manoj,' said Gen Kapur after the initial exchange of pleasantries, 'I am sending you to 2 RR (Rashtriya Rifles) as the Commanding Officer. Be prepared to move at short notice.' I was dumbstruck as a thousand thoughts swirled through my mind. It is the dream of every officer to command the unit one is commissioned into—in my case, 7 SIKH LI. I had been approved for the select rank of Colonel earlier that year and was looking forward to rejoining my unit, and had even been formulating some plans on what to do. The unit, the paltan, is your family. Over the years, we had been together everywhere, from Sikkim to Bikaner, from Kargil to Trincomalee in Sri Lanka. I knew my boys and they knew me. To leave all that and to go to an entirely new unit and to start afresh? That's so unfair!

I tried in vain to reason with Gen Kapur. 'Sir,' I remonstrated, 'I was your Adjutant, your right-hand man, and Pune type to boot, you cannot do this to me.' Gen Kapur was unmoved. I had no choice but to accept his decision, as I had done once earlier too and it had been to my benefit. In 1986, we were on routine exercises in Sikkim. We were camped somewhere close to Nathu La, at a height of about 10,000 feet. It was end-September, early October and already bitterly cold, with a faint dusting of snow on the mountain tops. In the snow tent that was our Mess, Col Kapur had come in one evening waving two posting orders, both for me, to two different places. He was fuming, because he had, in fact, requested that since the unit had just moved into a new location, the team should remain

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